Nouns — Grammar Workshop

Plurals, countability, possessives and agreement

English Language Minor — Grammar | Name: _____ | Date: _____

🔍 Phase 1 — Spot the Non-Native Speaker

Before learning the rules, see how many noun errors you can spot on instinct alone.

Both guests below gave 5 stars and had a positive experience. One review was written by a native English speaker, the other by a non-native speaker. Read both carefully, then answer the questions below.

Sarah T.
January 2026

★★★★★

Lovely apartment right on the canal. The host's recommendations were spot-on — we followed her advice and found the best Indonesian restaurant in the Jordaan. The children's play area nearby was a bonus. Plenty of space for our luggage and the furniture was modern and comfortable. The only minor issue was the stairs — the building's staircase is very steep, but that's just Amsterdam! Would definitely stay again.

Cleanliness 5.0 | Location 5.0

Marco L.
December 2025

★★★★★

Very nice apartment with a lot of space and modern furnitures. The host gave us many good advices about the city and the neighbourhood's restaurants were amazing. We had three luggages and there was enough room for everything. The apartment his location is perfect — only few minutes from the centrum. The staffs at the nearby café were also very friendly. We had a wonderful experiences and will come back for sure!

Cleanliness 5.0 | Location 5.0

1. Which review was written by the non-native speaker? _____

2. List the errors that gave it away and write the correct version next to each one:

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

3. Compare with a partner. Which ones are you unsure about?

_____

_____

📝 Phase 2 — Guided Practice

Now learn the rules and apply them in focused exercises — one category at a time.

2A — Plural Forms

Quick Reference

Regular: + *-s* (student → students)
-s, -ss, -ch, -sh, -x: + *-es* (watch → watches)
-y (after consonant): -y → *-ies* (hobby → hobbies)
-y (after vowel): + *-s* (boy → boys)
-f(e): f(e) → *-ves* (wolf → wolves) — but: belief → beliefs
-o: + *-es* (hero → heroes) — but: piano → pianos
Irregular: man → men, child → children, tooth → teeth
No change: sheep → sheep, deer → deer, fish → fish
Latin/Greek: crisis → crises, phenomenon → phenomena
Compounds: mother-in-law → mother**s**-in-law

Never use -'s to make a plural! (1960s, not 1960's)

Exercise A1 — Write the plural form:

Practise forming regular, irregular, and tricky plurals.

1.	life	_____	**2.**	goose	_____	**3.**	hobby	_____
4.	crisis	_____	**5.**	branch	_____	**6.**	half	_____
7.	deer	_____	**8.**	woman	_____	**9.**	volcano	_____
10.	tooth	_____	**11.**	phenomenon	_____	**12.**	knife	_____
13.	father-in-law	_____	**14.**	secretary	_____	**15.**	criterion	_____

Exercise A2 — Correct the plural errors in these sentences:

Spot and fix plural mistakes in full sentences.

1. The two **woman** left their **scarf's** on the **benchs** near the **churchs**.

_____

2. Several **wolfs** were spotted near the **citys** in the **1990's**.

_____

3. The **childs** lost three **tooths** and both their **watchs** during the trip.

_____

4. Three **pianoes** and two **heros** were featured in yesterday's concert at the **musea**.

_____

2B — Countable vs. Uncountable

Quick Reference

Uncountable nouns cannot take a/an or a plural: *money* (not *a money / moneys*), *advice*, *furniture*, *information*, *luggage*, *research*, *knowledge*, *equipment*.

To count them, add a unit: *a piece of advice*, *two glasses of water*, *three items of furniture*.

Countable only: many, few, fewer, fewest, a number of, several
Uncountable only: much, little, less, least, a bit of, a great deal of
Both: a lot of, plenty of, enough, some, any, hardly any, more, most
Watch out: Some nouns can be both! (*hair* vs. *hairs*, *experience* vs. *experiences*)

Exercise B1 — Mark each noun as C (countable) or U (uncountable), then tick all the quantifiers that work with it:

Learn which nouns you can count and which quantifiers go with them.

Noun	C / U	Choose the quantifier(s) that work with this noun
research		☐ many ☐ much ☐ some ☐ several
idea		☐ few ☐ little ☐ several ☐ a great deal of
information		☐ a lot of ☐ numerous ☐ plenty of ☐ many
furniture		☐ pieces of ☐ some ☐ fewer ☐ less
advice		☐ a bit of ☐ several ☐ a great deal of ☐ many
experience (concept)		☐ much ☐ many ☐ a lot of ☐ fewer
experience (event)		☐ much ☐ many ☐ a lot of ☐ fewer
luggage		☐ a few ☐ a little ☐ enough ☐ several

Exercise B2 — Correct the errors in these sentences (some may be correct):
Find and fix countability errors in context.

1. I have many **homeworks** to do and I need some **advices** on how to manage my time.

2. We bought three new **furnitures** for the living room.

3. There are too **many traffic** on the roads and not **enough informations** about delays.

4. She has a lot of **experience** and gave me a useful **piece of advice**.

5. We need to buy **a bread** and **a rice** for dinner tonight.

6. He has made a lot **progress** recently but still has **few knowledge** of the subject.

2C — Possessives

Quick Reference

Singular: + *'s* → my sister**'s** name
Regular plural: + ' → my sisters**'** names
Irregular plural: + *'s* → the children**'s** toys
Names ending in -s: both OK → James**'s** / James**'** dog
People/animals: use *'s* / ' → the dog's bone
Things: use *the … of …* → the name of the book
Also with 's: yesterday's paper, a winter's tale, at the baker's

Dutch interference: *Jan z'n fiets ≠ *John his bike →* ***John's bike****. De fiets van Jan ≠ *The bike of John →* ***John's bike****.*

Exercise C1 — Write the correct possessive form:
Practise forming possessives with singular, plural, and irregular nouns.

1. the children + toys _____
2. my sister-in-law + car _____
3. both women + purses _____
4. the country + economy _____
5. several students + papers _____
6. my boss + office _____
7. the bridge + foundation _____
8. the book + title _____

Exercise C2 — Fix the Dutch interference. Rewrite each sentence in full, replacing every "his/her" possessive and "of" construction with the correct English form:
Rewrite Dutch-influenced possessives into natural English.

1. Thomas his laptop was on the table of the teacher.

2. The car of my father needs new tires because the tires of the car are worn out.

3. Yesterday paper had an article about the problems of the government.

4. Lisa her sisters' their names are written on the door of the room.

2D — Agreement

Quick Reference

Uncountable nouns take a singular verb: *Water **flows** through the pipes.*
Linked subjects take plural: *Simon and Anita **go** sailing.*
Two nouns, one idea → singular: *Bread and butter **was** all we had.*
Measurement phrases → singular: *Ten miles **is** too far.*

Group nouns (family, government, team):
UK: plural → *The government **are** planning...*
US: singular → *The government **is** planning...*
Always plural: cattle, livestock, people, police, staff
Names for one thing → singular: *The United States **has**...*

Exercise D1 — Choose the correct verb form. Where both UK and US forms are possible, give both.

Match verbs to tricky subjects: group nouns, measurements, and more.

1. The police _____ (is / are) investigating three separate incidents.

2. Physics, as well as mathematics, _____ (requires / require) strong analytical skills.

3. A number of spectators _____ (was / were) asked to leave the stadium.

4. The jury, along with the judge, _____ (has / have) deliberated for three days.

5. Neither the teachers nor the principal _____ (wants / want) to cancel the event.

6. Fifty euros _____ (is / are) too much for that jacket.

7. The staff _____ (is / are) unhappy about the new policy.

8. Half of the cake _____ (has / have) been eaten, while half of the cookies _____ (remains / remain) untouched.

9. Fish and chips _____ (is / are) my favourite meal.

10. The United Nations _____ (has / have) issued a statement about the crisis.

✍️ Phase 3 — Write a Review

Put it all together: use what you've practised in your own writing.

You had a terrible weekend at a countryside B&B. Write a TripAdvisor review. Use at least 10 of these words in their correct form.

child · sheep · furniture · mouse · advice · owner · wife · staff · police · experience · roof · knife · water · tooth · luggage · criterion · woman · family

Peer Review — swap with a partner and check:

☐ 10+ words used ☐ Plural forms correct ☐ Uncountable nouns correct ☐ Possessives correct ☐ Agreement correct